

CJ 540

The Ethics of Social Research



Professor Burrell Vann Jr

The background is a solid dark teal color. It is decorated with several abstract, scribbled shapes in white and light teal. There is a small white scribble in the top left, a large white scribble in the top right, a small light teal scribble in the top right, a small light teal scribble in the bottom left, a large white scribble in the bottom left, a small light teal scribble in the bottom left, and a small white scribble in the bottom right.

Why do we need
ethics in social
research?

RISK: ANONYMITY &
CONFIDENTIALITY

Laud Humphreys - The Tearoom Trade

PSYCHOLOGICAL HARM:
OBEDIENCE

Stanley Milgram

PSYCHOLOGICAL HARM: POWER &
ROLE CONFORMITY

Philip Zimbardo

Ethical Controversies

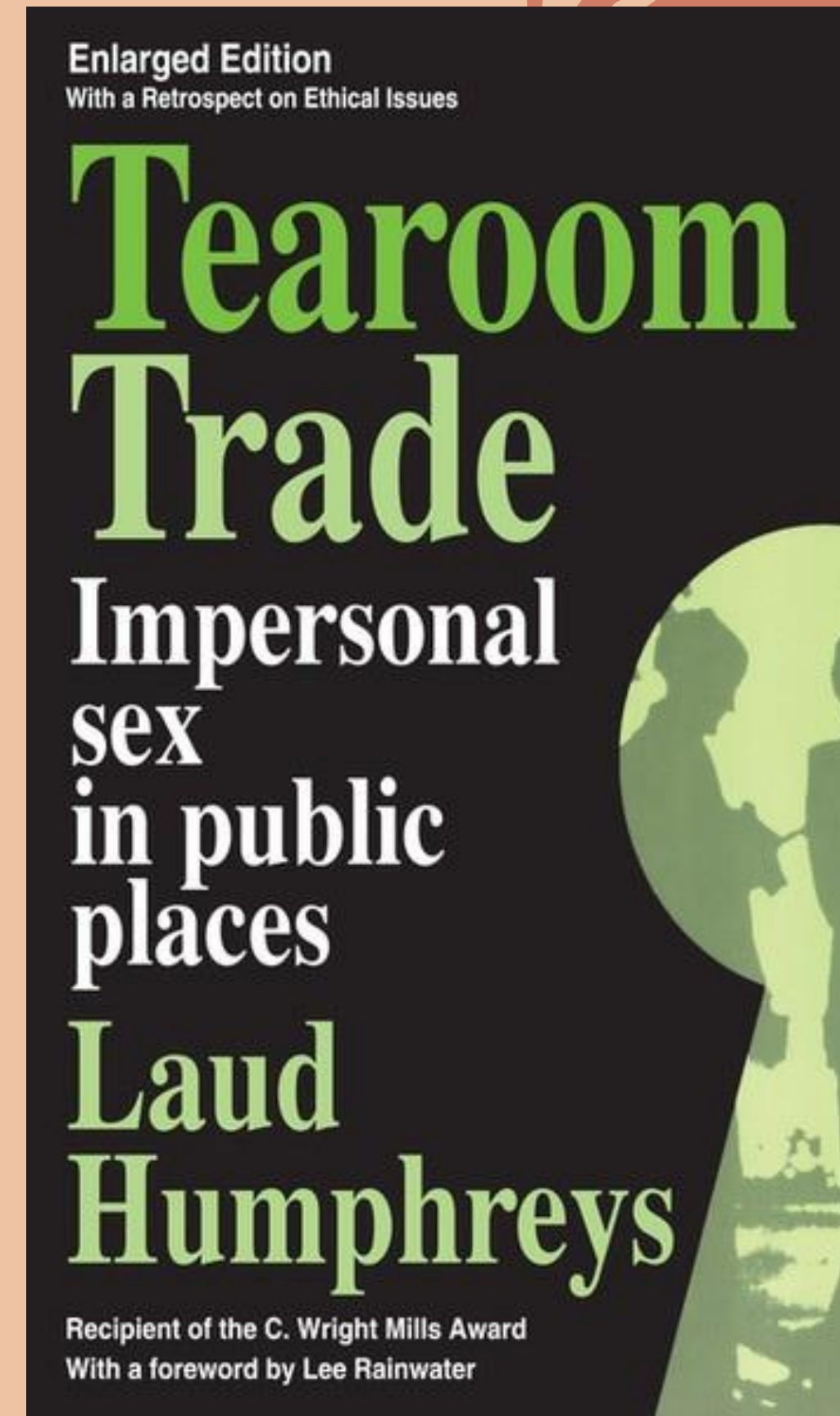
The Tearoom Trade

LAUD HUMPHREYS

- Studied gay sexual activities in public restrooms in parks
- Volunteered to become “watchqueen”/police lookout while men engaged in sexual activity
- Wanted to know "who" engaged in gay public sex and why

ETHICAL PROBLEMS

- Collected license numbers of participants' cars
- Linked plates to addresses and met them at their homes to interview/confront them



IGNORING ANONYMITY AND
CONFIDENTIALITY

Shockingly Obedient

STANLEY MILGRAM

- Participants imitated a laboratory-based World War II controversy
- Participants were assigned job of “teacher” – to teach a list of words to the “student” (who worked with Milgram).
- If the student got the word wrong, the teacher would administer increasing levels of shocks to the student, up to and beyond fatal levels

ETHICAL PROBLEMS

- Deceived teachers into believing they killed someone
- Forced participants through intimidation, stress, yelling, to keep increasing levels of shock, against their will (in most cases)



PSYCHOLOGICAL HARM

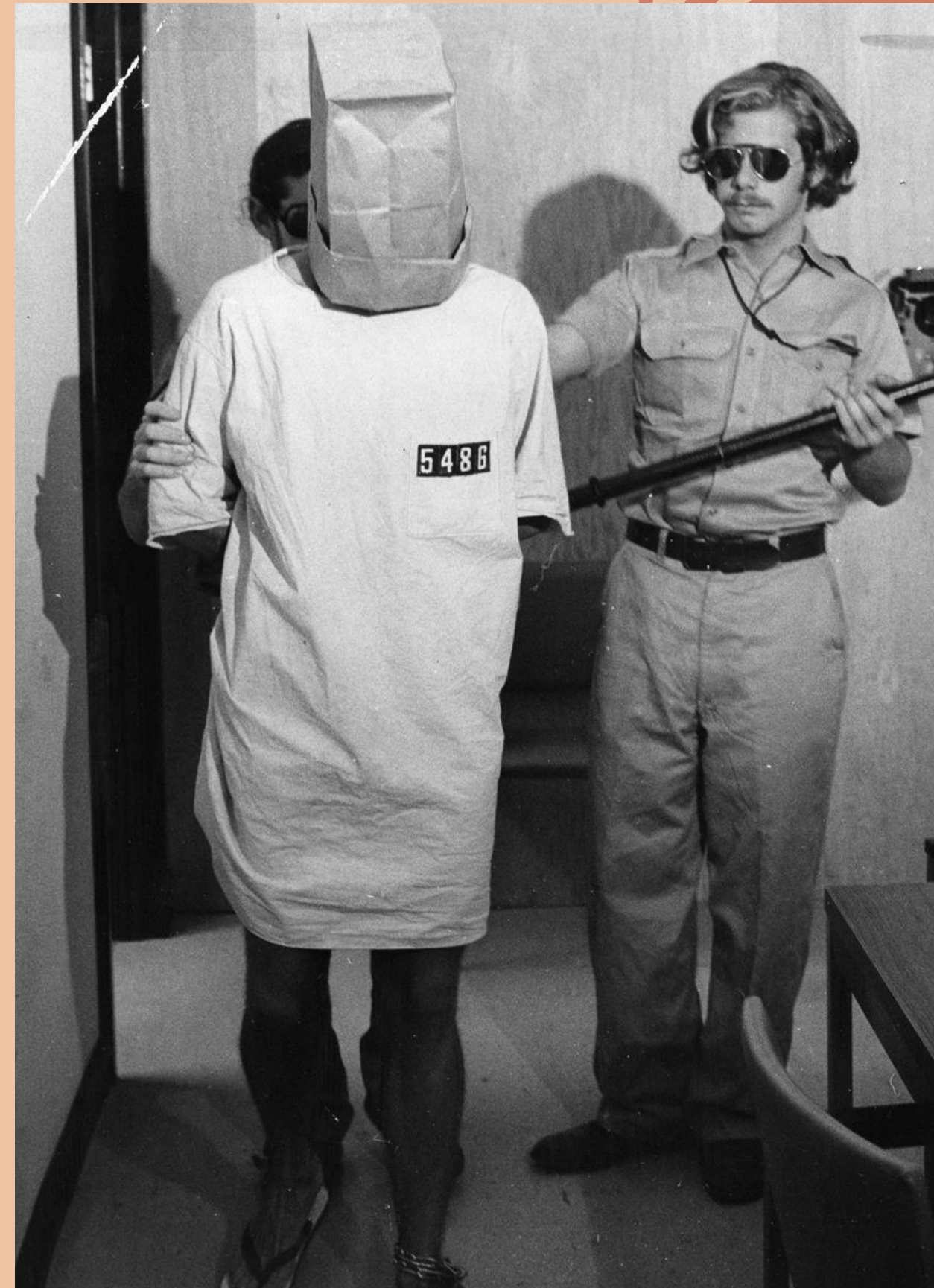
Stanford Prison Experiment

PHILIP ZIMBARDO

- Wanted to understand if authoritarian, torturous, brutal, and sadistic behavior was dispositional (personal characteristics) or situational (environmental).
- Randomly assigned Stanford students to "guard" or "prisoner" roles
- Guards immediately accepted authoritarian role, treated prisoners

ETHICAL PROBLEMS

- After six days, experiment abandoned as "guards" began physically and psychologically torturing
- Zimbardo didn't allow early exit, participants not debriefed, no consent given
- Lasting psychological trauma



PSYCHOLOGICAL HARM

Ethical Standards in Social Research

Rules developed and designed to help protect human research participants (subjects) from harm and risk



Who sets the ethical standards?

PROFESSIONAL ORGANIZATIONS

Organizations for each discipline set standards for their conducting human subjects research in their discipline

INSTITUTIONAL REVIEW BOARDS (IRB)

Panel of experts at each institution that enforces these rules



Institutional Review Board

ENSURING RESEARCHERS FOLLOW ETHICAL GUIDELINES FOR HUMAN SUBJECTS

Who? What?

- A panel of faculty/experts who review all research proposals involving human participants

Where?

- Every institution that is federally-funded and/or conducts research must have an IRB.
 - SDSU IRB

Why?

- To guarantee participants' rights will be protected
- To ensure that the risks faced by human participants in research are minimal

When?

- Usually meets once per month



Institutional Review Board

ENSURING RESEARCHERS FOLLOW ETHICAL GUIDELINES FOR HUMAN SUBJECTS

What ethical assurances does IRB want you to provide to your participants?

VOLUNTARY PARTICIPATION

No one should be forced to participate

NO HARM

People being researched should never be injured (physically, mentally, emotionally, socially, psychologically)

ANONYMITY

A guarantee that neither the researchers nor the readers of the findings can identify a given response with a given participant

CONFIDENTIALITY

A guarantee that if the researcher can identify a given person's responses, they promise not to do so publicly

- unless subpoenaed or under oath

USE OF DECEPTION

A guarantee that if participants misled in order to obtain information in a covert way, they are debriefed about deception after the conclusion of the study

- Needs strong scientific justification.



Institutional Review Board

ENSURING RESEARCHERS FOLLOW ETHICAL GUIDELINES FOR HUMAN SUBJECTS

How do you inform participants that you are providing them with these assurances?

INFORMED CONSENT

- A legal form that participants must sign to participate
- Acknowledges that their voluntary participation in a research project is based on their full understanding of the possible harms and risks involved
- Outlines researchers steps to ensure anonymity and confidentiality
- Describes how much time the study will take
- Lists contact information for researchers for follow-up





Which projects require IRB approval?

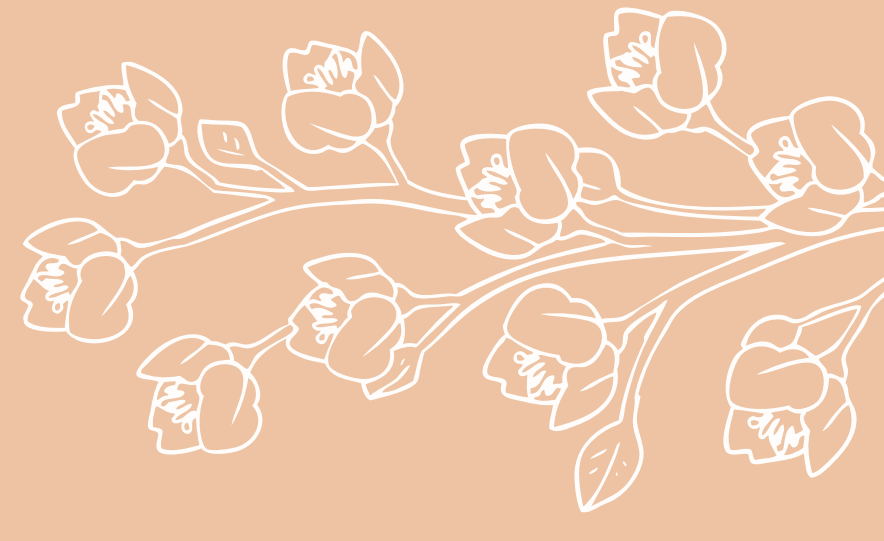
ALL PROJECTS USING DIRECT OBSERVATIONS OF HUMAN SUBJECTS

PRIMARY DATA COLLECTION AND ANALYSIS

- Interviews
- Surveys
- Ethnography
- Experiment
- Participant Observation



Which projects do not require IRB approval?



ALL PROJECTS NOT USING DIRECT OBSERVATIONS OF HUMAN
SUBJECTS

SECONDARY DATA ANALYSIS

- Content Analysis
- Text Analysis
- Analysis of Previously Administered Surveys
- Census
- Publicly-Available Data (where participants remain anonymous)

Steps to jumpstart your ethical research

PRIMARY

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

Develop research questions about the relationship between variables

MATERIALS & PROCEDURES

Develop materials and procedures for answering the research question (e.g. questionnaire, interview/topic guide, manipulation conditions) and informed consent document

IRB

Submit an application to the IRB at your institution, outlining the procedures to answer the human subjects research question, include materials as well as the informed consent form. Wait for approval

BEGIN DATA COLLECTION

Only after IRB has approved the research protocol can the researcher begin data collection

SECONDARY

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

Develop research questions about the relationship between variables

MATERIALS & PROCEDURES

Identify data sets that include variables that can be used to answer the research question

BEGIN DATA COLLECTION

Gather/merge data sets. Caution: Some data sets may require researchers to request special access

